

Almost Sure Convergence: Selected Proofs

MBZUAI: SDS8102 – Advanced Mathematical Statistics

Kolmogorov's criterion, Three-series theorem, SLLN
Uniqueness of Characteristic Functions, and Lévy's Continuity Theorem

1. Kolmogorov's Inequality and Almost-Sure Convergence

We now develop a collection of tools for proving almost-sure convergence of sums of independent random variables. These results will also lead to a proof of the strong law of large numbers.

1.1. Kolmogorov's Maximal Inequality

Chebyshev's inequality controls the value of a partial sum at a fixed time. For almost-sure convergence, however, we often need to control the entire path of partial sums simultaneously.

Theorem 1.1 (Kolmogorov's Maximal Inequality). *Let $X_1, \dots, X_n$ be independent random variables satisfying*

$$\mathbb{E}[X_i] = 0, \quad \text{Var}(X_i) < \infty.$$

Define

$$S_k = \sum_{i=1}^k X_i.$$

Then, for every $\lambda > 0$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\max_{1 \leq k \leq n} |S_k| \geq \lambda\right) \leq \frac{\text{Var}(S_n)}{\lambda^2} = \frac{1}{\lambda^2} \sum_{i=1}^n \text{Var}(X_i).$$

Proof. Define the disjoint events

$$A_k = \{|S_j| < \lambda \text{ for } j < k, \quad |S_k| \geq \lambda\}.$$

Thus A_k is the event that the partial sums first cross the level λ at time k . Moreover,

$$\bigcup_{k=1}^n A_k = \left\{ \max_{1 \leq k \leq n} |S_k| \geq \lambda \right\}.$$

Write

$$S_n = S_k + (S_n - S_k).$$

Since A_k depends only on $X_1, \dots, X_k$, while $S_n - S_k$ depends only on $X_{k+1}, \dots, X_n$, independence and centering give

$$\mathbb{E}[S_k(S_n - S_k)\mathbf{1}_{A_k}] = 0.$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[S_n^2 \mathbf{1}_{A_k}] &= \mathbb{E}[S_k^2 \mathbf{1}_{A_k}] + \mathbb{E}[(S_n - S_k)^2 \mathbf{1}_{A_k}] \\ &\geq \mathbb{E}[S_k^2 \mathbf{1}_{A_k}] \\ &\geq \lambda^2 \mathbb{P}(A_k). \end{aligned}$$

Summing over k and using disjointness,

$$\mathbb{E}[S_n^2] \geq \sum_{k=1}^n \mathbb{E}[S_n^2 \mathbf{1}_{A_k}] \geq \lambda^2 \sum_{k=1}^n \mathbb{P}(A_k).$$

Hence

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\max_{1 \leq k \leq n} |S_k| \geq \lambda\right) \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}[S_n^2]}{\lambda^2}.$$

Since the variables are independent and centered,

$$\mathbb{E}[S_n^2] = \text{Var}(S_n) = \sum_{i=1}^n \text{Var}(X_i).$$

■

Why this is stronger than Chebyshev. Chebyshev gives only

$$\mathbb{P}(|S_n| \geq \lambda) \leq \frac{\text{Var}(S_n)}{\lambda^2},$$

whereas Kolmogorov's inequality controls

$$\max_{1 \leq k \leq n} |S_k|$$

with exactly the same upper bound.

1.2. Kolmogorov's Convergence Criterion

Theorem 1.2 (Kolmogorov's Convergence Criterion). *Let $X_1, X_2, \dots$ be independent random variables with*

$$\mathbb{E}[X_n] = 0, \quad \text{Var}(X_n) < \infty.$$

If

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \text{Var}(X_n) < \infty,$$

then

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} X_n$$

converges almost surely.

Proof. Let

$$S_n = \sum_{k=1}^n X_k.$$

We show that $\{S_n\}$ is almost surely Cauchy.

For $m > n$, Kolmogorov's maximal inequality applied to

$$X_{n+1}, \dots, X_m$$

gives

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\max_{n < k \leq m} |S_k - S_n| > \varepsilon\right) \leq \frac{1}{\varepsilon^2} \sum_{j=n+1}^m \text{Var}(X_j).$$

Letting $m \rightarrow \infty$,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\sup_{k>n} |S_k - S_n| > \varepsilon\right) \leq \frac{1}{\varepsilon^2} \sum_{j=n+1}^{\infty} \text{Var}(X_j).$$

Since

$$\sum_{j=1}^{\infty} \text{Var}(X_j) < \infty,$$

the right-hand side converges to zero.

To obtain an almost-sure statement, choose integers n_r such that

$$\sum_{j=n_r+1}^{\infty} \text{Var}(X_j) \leq 2^{-3r}.$$

Then

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\sup_{k>n_r} |S_k - S_{n_r}| > 2^{-r}\right) \leq 2^{2r} 2^{-3r} = 2^{-r}.$$

The probabilities are summable. Hence, by the Borel–Cantelli lemma, almost surely,

$$\sup_{k>n_r} |S_k - S_{n_r}| \leq 2^{-r}$$

for all sufficiently large r .

Thus $\{S_n\}$ is almost surely Cauchy, and therefore converges almost surely. ■

1.3. Kolmogorov's Three-Series Theorem

The convergence criterion requires finite variances and summability of those variances. The three-series theorem gives a necessary and sufficient condition for almost-sure convergence without assuming finite second moments.

Let $X_1, X_2, \dots$ be independent. Fix $A > 0$ and define the truncated variables

$$X_n^{(A)} = X_n \mathbf{1}\{|X_n| \leq A\}.$$

Theorem 1.3 (Kolmogorov's Three-Series Theorem). *The series*

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} X_n$$

converges almost surely if and only if, for some $A > 0$, the following three series satisfy:

1.

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(|X_n| > A) < \infty;$$

2.

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{E}[X_n^{(A)}] \quad \text{converges};$$

3.

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \text{Var}(X_n^{(A)}) < \infty.$$

The three conditions control three distinct phenomena:

$\sum \mathbb{P}(X_n > A) < \infty$: large jumps occur only finitely often, $\sum \mathbb{E}[X_n^{(A)}]$ converges : the deterministic drift converges, $\sum \text{Var}(X_n^{(A)}) < \infty$: the centered random fluctuations converge.

Indeed, by Borel–Cantelli, the first condition implies

$$X_n = X_n^{(A)}$$

eventually almost surely. Writing

$$X_n^{(A)} = (X_n^{(A)} - \mathbb{E}[X_n^{(A)}]) + \mathbb{E}[X_n^{(A)}],$$

the second condition controls the deterministic part, while the third condition, together with Kolmogorov's convergence criterion, controls the centered random part.

2. The Strong Law of Large Numbers

2.1. The Finite-Variance Case

We first prove the strong law under a finite-variance assumption.

Theorem 2.1 (Strong Law: Finite-Variance Case). *Let $X_1, X_2, \dots$ be i.i.d. with*

$$\mathbb{E}[X_1] = \mu, \quad \text{Var}(X_1) = \sigma^2 < \infty.$$

Then

$$\bar{X}_n = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n X_i \xrightarrow{a.s.} \mu.$$

Proof. Define

$$Y_n = X_n - \mu.$$

Then

$$\mathbb{E}[Y_n] = 0, \quad \text{Var}(Y_n) = \sigma^2.$$

Consider the series

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{Y_n}{n}.$$

The terms are independent and centered, and

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \text{Var}\left(\frac{Y_n}{n}\right) = \sigma^2 \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^2} < \infty.$$

By Kolmogorov's convergence criterion,

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{Y_n}{n}$$

converges almost surely.

We now use Kronecker's lemma.

Lemma 2.2 (Kronecker). *If*

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{a_n}{n}$$

converges, then

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n a_k \longrightarrow 0.$$

Applying the lemma pathwise with $a_n = Y_n$ gives

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n Y_k \xrightarrow{a.s.} 0.$$

Therefore

$$\bar{X}_n - \mu = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n (X_k - \mu) \xrightarrow{a.s.} 0.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\bar{X}_n \xrightarrow{a.s.} \mu.}$$

■

2.2. The General i.i.d. Strong Law

The finite-variance assumption is unnecessary. For i.i.d. random variables, existence of the first absolute moment is enough.

Theorem 2.3 (Kolmogorov's Strong Law). *Let $X_1, X_2, \dots$ be i.i.d. and suppose*

$$\mathbb{E}|X_1| < \infty.$$

Then

$$\bar{X}_n \xrightarrow{a.s.} \mathbb{E}[X_1].$$

Proof. Write

$$\mu = \mathbb{E}[X_1].$$

Define the truncated variables

$$Y_n = X_n \mathbf{1}\{|X_n| \leq n\}.$$

We proceed in three steps.

Step 1: truncation changes only finitely many terms.

Since X_n are identically distributed,

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(X_n \neq Y_n) = \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(|X_1| > n).$$

Because $\mathbb{E}|X_1| < \infty$,

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \mathbb{P}(|X_1| > n) < \infty.$$

Hence Borel–Cantelli gives

$$\mathbb{P}(X_n \neq Y_n \text{ infinitely often}) = 0.$$

Thus

$$X_n = Y_n$$

eventually almost surely, and consequently

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n (X_k - Y_k) \xrightarrow{a.s.} 0.$$

Step 2: control the centered truncated variables.

Consider

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{Y_n - \mathbb{E}[Y_n]}{n}.$$

The terms are independent and centered. We claim

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{\text{Var}(Y_n)}{n^2} < \infty.$$

Since

$$\text{Var}(Y_n) \leq \mathbb{E}[Y_n^2],$$

it is enough to show

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^2} \mathbb{E} [X_1^2 \mathbf{1}_{\{|X_1| \leq n\}}] < \infty.$$

By Tonelli's theorem,

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n^2} \mathbb{E} [X_1^2 \mathbf{1}_{\{|X_1| \leq n\}}] = \mathbb{E} \left[X_1^2 \sum_{n \geq |X_1|} \frac{1}{n^2} \right].$$

For $x \geq 1$,

$$\sum_{n \geq x} \frac{1}{n^2} \leq \frac{C}{x}.$$

Therefore

$$X_1^2 \sum_{n \geq |X_1|} \frac{1}{n^2} \leq C|X_1|$$

up to an irrelevant bounded contribution when $|X_1| < 1$. Since $\mathbb{E}|X_1| < \infty$,

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{\text{Var}(Y_n)}{n^2} < \infty.$$

Kolmogorov's convergence criterion therefore gives

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{Y_n - \mathbb{E}[Y_n]}{n} \text{ converges almost surely.}$$

By Kronecker's lemma,

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n (Y_k - \mathbb{E}[Y_k]) \xrightarrow{a.s.} 0.$$

Step 3: identify the deterministic limit.

Since

$$Y_n = X_1 \mathbf{1}\{|X_1| \leq n\} \quad \text{in distribution,}$$

dominated convergence gives

$$\mathbb{E}[Y_n] = \mathbb{E}[X_1 \mathbf{1}\{|X_1| \leq n\}] \longrightarrow \mathbb{E}[X_1] = \mu.$$

Hence, by Cesàro convergence,

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n \mathbb{E}[Y_k] \longrightarrow \mu.$$

Combining the three steps,

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n X_k &= \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n (X_k - Y_k) + \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n (Y_k - \mathbb{E}[Y_k]) + \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n \mathbb{E}[Y_k] \\ &\xrightarrow{a.s.} 0 + 0 + \mu. \end{aligned}$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{\bar{X}_n \xrightarrow{a.s.} \mathbb{E}[X_1].}$$

■